

toms of what can be a very serious problem for an organisation.

Because spyware and adware exist as independent executable programs, these programs can monitor keystrokes, scan files on the hard drive, install other spyware programs, read cookies, and change the default home page on the Web browser. The programs continually relay this information back to the spyware author, who either uses it for advertising or marketing purposes or sells the information to another party.

Organisations whose very existence depends on protecting their valuable intellectual property cannot risk losing this competitive edge to information thieves. And organisations whose investors and clients rely on them to safeguard and protect personal, medical, and financial information, to name just a few, cannot afford to question whether critical information is being accessed by spyware. Organisations that need to demonstrate compliance with government regulations for information security are especially affected by spyware.

When spyware is part of the corporate computing environment, capturing confidential information or secretly perusing files and applications, regulatory compliance is virtually impossible. Even in computing environments that encrypt data, spyware remains a threat to the security of corporate data because its keystroke-logging components capture input before it can be encrypted.

Spyware and adware significantly increases the burden of IT Help Desk staff by causing application conflicts, malfunction of legitimate applications, and system instability. Many times, the IT Help Desk staff may have to re-image the desktops/laptops to completely get rid of problems caused by spyware.

When spyware and adware programs send information back to their home servers, they must connect to the Internet. In doing this, spyware can cause unexpected lockups and many other problems in Windows. When these events occur, calls to IT Help Desks increase as employees struggle to understand why their computers